At least on Fridays no shop assistant in the market was likely to ask us as to which security company we were working for! Soon the air force and the navy followed suit. Once a week, we felt like warriors even if we were far removed from the battlefield. This was one way of showing solidarity and conveying that we shared their challenges and hardships in spirit. I was very clear about wearing of medals and regimental badges of rank on the epaulettes: in peace it was okay, except in a combat zone or during training exercises, when we would need no orders to strip everything off from the combat dress.

A very significant development took place when we, the three service chiefs, happened to attend the presidential fleet review at Visakhapatnam on 13 February 2006. Most of us from the army or the air force had never participated in such an event before. For the navy, it is a very important professional event where they showcase their *'shipshapeness'*, or the state of operational readiness, standard of training and battleworthiness of ships. The president was taken on board a submarine by the naval chief for a brief diving manoeuvre. The rest of us had a briefing session followed by tea. There were a host of mediapersons present at the event. As usual, they were looking out for some interesting story. And as happens so often, the breaking news is not related to the event of the day. This time around too, it happened something like this – sensing an opportune moment, a group of journalists swooped down on me. Before I knew what was happening, a few mikes were jabbed towards my face. Then, one of them asked me if it was true that the Indian Army had refused to cooperate with the Sachar Committee. It was a seven-member committee, led by Justice Rajinder Sachar, which was carrying out a Muslim-specific survey as part of the government's efforts to promote 'minority welfare' by studying their social, economic and education status.